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No Chalk and Talk

Instead use better-designed, fun-filled and more relevant textbooks

When I established the Jiva Public School in Faridabad 1994, I was eager to introduce new ideas to Indian teachers that would help undo the outmoded factory-style education that was, and still is, hindering India's progress. Before our first classes started, I spent three weeks training our instructors in activity-based methods that would make learning interactive and enjoyable for the children.

However, when the students arrived, I found the teachers resorting to traditional chalk-and-talk methods, teaching like dictators and forcing the students into lockstep, like cadets in the mili-

secrets to writing a good textbook:

► **Localise it.** Make the books look and feel Indian. Avoid using illustrations of foreign looking children named Johnny and Sally in western outfits, and show people the way they really are, some with dark skins, wearing saris, and people with names like Venkatesh and Harpreet Kaur.

► **Make the layout friendly.** Don't use tiny fonts and small margins. Use large serif fonts (extra large for primary students) with plenty of spacing so it makes reading easier and more pleasurable.

► **Make it activity-based.** Put activities in the books that get children to interact with each other. Let them discuss, debate, brainstorm, solve problems in groups and even play learning games. This builds social skills, a more important determinant of success in life than one's IQ level.

► **Focus on Multiple Intelligences.** There are eight intelligences—bodily, interpersonal, linguistic, logical, visual, musical, intrapersonal and naturalistic. Ensure you have activities that promote all types of abilities.

► **Ask deep questions.** What would it be like to live in the Indus Civilisation as a child? How do historians accurately know about this era and do all of them agree about the research?

► **Make it meaningful.** Help children understand why this information is relevant to their lives. Aspiring rock stars in a trigonometry class would find concepts like waves, frequency and amplitude much more interesting when they see how they form the basis of musical sound.

► **Add in a dash of fun.** There is plenty of scope for poetry and rap in the science textbook. While discipline in life is a must, so is playfulness.

In the digital age, teachers are yet another 'channel' for kids to watch. If the tools they have to work with are built on principles of the past, it will predispose them to teach in antiquated, unimaginative ways. Kids will tune them out. However, designing materials around more holistic and creative principles results in entirely different products—ones that inherently inspire learners. Education is poised for immense change right now and textbooks are the main lynchpins holding us back. I am confident that this trend will change as, if I may adapt the famous quote, "No one can stop a textbook whose time has come." ■

0.7%

of the GDP is the present support for higher education in India. Ideally, it should be at least 1.5%.

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tary. Whatever I taught them seemed to have gone right out the window. Upon careful examination, I found that the culprit was the textbooks that they were using—painfully dull volumes, filled with unimportant details, presented in a suffocating manner. I then decided to dedicate a significant amount of time to building a better textbook. Seventy books later, I have seen my work reach the corners of India, delighting both teachers and learners, who regularly write to me to say how their classrooms have been transformed and how learning has become fun. Here are my seven